

A prompt is a small work specification

WRITE IT — like a requirement

task and audience first · then only the requirements that resolve ambiguity

THE SKELETON — EVERY PROMPT

Purpose & audience: help [reader] make [decision] or complete [task].

Sources & scope: use [source / version / period]; include [scope]; exclude [items].

Selected requirements: only the types that resolve ambiguity for THIS artifact — a simple task needs a few, not all.

Acceptance evidence: check [specific result] against [source, calculation, or observable test].

Missing info & boundaries: if [gap or conflict]: state it, ask, or stop. Actions needing review: [actions].

REQUIREMENT TYPES — THE MENU (pick, don't fill)

Functional behavior — what it must do: filter, calculate, extract, compare, explain.

Data & provenance — allowed inputs, definitions, period, traceability.

Scope & exclusions — in, out, and explicitly outside the task.

Audience & use — who uses it, for which decision.

Role & working behavior — a perspective plus observable conduct; a title alone is weak.

Content & completeness — required topics, fields, limitations.

Method & business rules — formulas, denominators, missing-data treatment.

Structure & interface — sections, tabs, slides, columns, controls.

Tone & presentation — voice, reading level, units, formats.

Accessibility & usability — labels, contrast, keyboard, understandable language.

Quality & acceptance — observable correctness and completeness criteria.

Constraints & authority — allowed tools, approvals, stop conditions.

Delivery & compatibility — file type, editability, offline use, destination.

Maintenance & reuse — refresh procedure, versions, reusable parameters.

REQUIREMENT QUALITY — IS EACH ONE...

necessary · clear · complete enough · consistent · feasible · singular · **verifiable**. A requirement you cannot check is a wish. Separate required outcomes from preferences; make trade-offs explicit.

BEFORE / AFTER — THE SUPPLIER CASE

Before: “Analyze the supplier data and tell me which supplier is worst.” — the model picks the rows, the metric, and “worst” for you, silently.

After: “Data tab, detail rows only (exclude the TOTAL row; the “n/a” is missing, not zero). Return rate = total returns ÷ total shipped per supplier, 2025-09 to 2026-08 — sums, never averaged percentages; defects stay separate. Rank, show numerator and denominator, reconcile to the TOTAL row, state one limitation, stop.”

Why it wins: each added line is a requirement type fixing one named weakness.

RUN IT — five tasks, one habit

produce the artifact, then check it against its own acceptance evidence

THE FIVE COURSE TASKS (workbook tabs 1-5)

1 Analyze data — define the metric and denominator; reconcile; state limits.

2 Build a dashboard — specify behavior in plain language: range, filters, grouping, metric switch, drill-down, Reset; one selection re-scopes every view.

3 Present findings — one message per slide; findings separated from recommendations; nothing invented.

4 Summarize email — current state; decisions WITH conditions; owners and dates; “Not stated” for gaps; replies stay drafts.

5 Explain clearly — fifth-grade reading level, adult tone; analogy limits stated; meaning preserved; 3-question check.

ACCEPTANCE CHECKS — BEFORE YOU TRUST IT

Trace — one output number back to its source records.

Recompute — one calculation independently (code or by hand).

Reconcile — totals against a number you already trust.

Exercise — every requested behavior once (filter, sort, reset, empty case).

Coverage — compare against the requirement list; missing = not done.

Read as the reader — can the audience act on it? That is validation.

Never accept “looks done”: ask for evidence — the test it ran and what it returned.

ASK vs DELEGATE

ASK — request an answer or draft; you read, check, decide. The specification above is enough.

DELEGATE — assign bounded work: add the inputs register, the checks that stop the run, permissions, gates for irreversible steps, and the finished-report format.

The boundary: prompt instructions request compliance — actual permissions and configured controls determine what a tool can DO. Reversible → proceed; irreversible → ask.

SAVE WHAT WORKS

Each reusable prompt: name · owner · version · the example that proved it · its acceptance check.

Where: the Course Workbook carries the five course prompts; the Template Creator and Configurator offer the same five task families with their requirement menus.

Refresh: facts about products and models expire — date them and re-verify before big reuse.